LEVEL DESIGN DOCUMENT

Escape from Morvath

A 2D top-down action dungeon crawler. Six areas, three seals, one dragon lord.



The Hatchery

START Tutorial. Hatch, find the Dragon Key.

DRAGON KEY OPENS THE GATE



The Sigil Halls

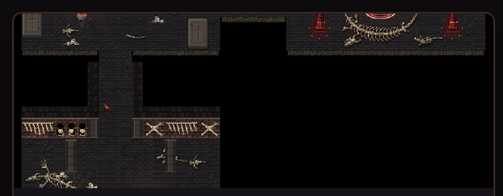
HUB Hub. Enemies Lv 1-3. Ember Shrine.

EITHER ORDER



The Ritual Chamber

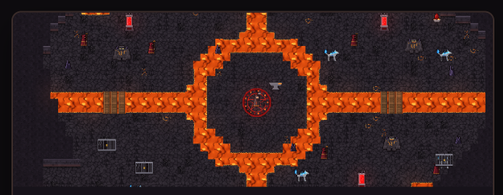
SEAL 1 Enemies Lv 5-7. Sigil Keeper.



The Dragon Crypt

SEAL 2 Enemies Lv 6-8. Sigil Keeper.

NEEDS 2 SEALS



The Crucible

SEAL 3 Enemies Lv 8-10. The Forgemaster.

NEEDS ALL 3 SEALS



The Throne Room

BOSS Morvath, the Dragon Lord. 4-part fight.

THE PITCH

For centuries, Dragon Lord Morvath has stolen the eggs of the fire dragons and drained their flame to feed his own. None of them ever hatched, until now. The player is that last egg: grow from whelp to dragon, break the three seals on his door and make him answer for every egg he took.

STRUCTURE

- **One central hub.** Six areas branch off one central hub. Every area has one entrance, and every return trip passes through the hub.
- **Three seals** gate the final fight: two wings in either order, then the Crucible, then Morvath.
- Morvath's door is visible from early on, and each broken seal shows on it.

PLAYER KIT

- **Fireball** from level 1: a directional bolt that flies the way the whelp faces.
- **Level 5:** the whelp evolves into a dragon and unlocks **Fire Circle**, a ring of fire around the player.
- **Ember Shrines** refill health and mana and add +10 fire damage for 30s (60s cooldown).
- **Searchable props** (books, urns, skeletons) hide potions and Dragon Scales, which raise max health for good.
- **World map (M)** tracks explored areas, seals and cleared rooms.

PROGRESSION

- XP from kills: 40 XP for level 2, then 50% more for each level. Every level adds 20 health and 10 mana.
- Enemy levels climb from 1 in the hub to 10 in the Crucible, so each wing is a step up.

BUILT WITH

Unity 6 (URP 2D), C#. Playable in the browser on itch.io.

AREA 1 | TUTORIAL

The Hatchery

Where the last egg hatches. Player level 1.



1. Egg nest and blood sigil
2. Whelp skeleton (Dragon Key)
3. Hatchery Log
4. Old urn
5. Stairs up

DESIGN GOAL

Teach the four verbs the whole game is built on (move, search, loot, travel) inside one small, safe room, and make the player feel the stakes before a single enemy appears.

PLAYER FLOW

1. **Hatch.** The egg sits chained to a pulsing blood sigil by a red beam. It cracks, the chain snaps and the sigil goes dark. Two lore pages then explain the egg hoard, and a small WASD to move hint fades once the whelp walks.
2. **The key.** A fallen whelp skeleton holds the Dragon Key. Searching (F) plays a collapse animation and the key drops into the bag.
3. **The log.** The Hatchery Log is a readable book: a keeper's note that the last egg has hatched. It plants Morvath's grudge in one line.
4. **Searchables.** The urn teaches that props can hide loot, so players keep checking them for the rest of the game.
5. **Leave.** Stairs need F to use, so the player never changes rooms by accident. They lead up to the locked gate in the Sigil Halls.

DESIGN NOTES

- No enemies here on purpose. The first threat waits on the other side of the gate.
- All three searchables sit inside one screen, so the player can always see what is left to check.
- Sparkles and an F prompt mark every interactable, so the room teaches itself without a tutorial text wall.

ITERATION

- Playtest: showing the lore before the hatch felt slow. Reverted so the hatch plays first, then the lore.
- Playtest: new players did not know how to move. Added the WASD hint above the whelp.
- The Hatchery Log text was rewritten to be short and personal instead of a big block of backstory.

AREA 2 | HUB

The Sigil Halls

The hub of Morvath's lair. Every route starts and ends here.



1. Arrival from the Hatchery
2. Starting gate (Dragon Key)
3. Caged wild whelps
4. Stairs to the Ritual Chamber
5. Stairs to the Dragon Crypt
6. Egg vault and Ember Shrine
7. Stairs to the Crucible (2 seals)
8. Morvath's sealed door (3 seals)

DESIGN GOAL

A readable hub that shows the player the end goal on day one. Morvath's sealed door is visible early, and every seal broken elsewhere lights up on it, so progress is always on screen.

PLAYER FLOW

1. Arrive in the gate room from the Hatchery.
2. The Dragon Key opens the starting gate. The first worms and Sigil Wardens wait beyond it.
3. Two wild whelps sit caged by the gate: a reminder that Morvath steals more than eggs.
4. The Ritual Chamber (first seal) is down the south-west stairs.
5. The Dragon Crypt (second seal) is up the north-east stairs. Both can be done in either order.
6. The egg vault holds drained egg husks and the first Ember Shrine (restore health and mana, +10 fire damage for 30s, 60s cooldown).
7. The Crucible stairs stay sealed until two seals are broken.
8. The blood-sigil door shows three seals. When all three break, the barrier shatters and the throne room opens.

ENCOUNTERS

ENEMY	LV	ROLE
Crypt Crawler (worm)	1-2	Burrows and resurfaces next to the player. 7 spawn points.
Sigil Warden	2-3	Ranged cultist. Keeps distance, casts blood bolts.

DESIGN NOTES

- Every route runs through the hub. Each wing has one clear entrance from it, so the player always knows the way back.
- Seals give a soft order without hard locks: two optional-order wings, then the Crucible, then Morvath.
- Playtest: players changed rooms by accident when walking over stairs. Stairs now need F to enter.

The Ritual Chamber

Holding cells, a collapsed forge and a blood ritual. Enemies level 5 to 7.



1. Arrival stairs
2. Holding cells
3. Collapsed forge and Ember Shrine
4. The ritual: Sigil Keeper

DESIGN GOAL

Introduce the rule both seal wings are built on: a guardian that cannot be hurt until the cultists channeling its shield are dead. The surrounding rooms build up to that fight one step at a time.

PLAYER FLOW

1. Arrive in the south-east corner of the holding cells.
2. **Holding cells.** Wild Frost and Moss whelps sit in cages. Two worm burrows (Lv 5) ambush the player beside the cells.
3. **Collapsed forge.** Lava seeps through the broken floor. A second Ember Shrine gives a full refill right before the fight.
4. **The ritual.** Four Blood Channelers stand on sigils around the Sigil Keeper. While any channeler lives, the Keeper is shielded, takes no damage and stays dormant. Kill all four and the shield shatters. Killing the Keeper breaks the first seal on Morvath's door.

ENCOUNTERS

ENEMY	LV	ROLE
Crypt Crawler	5	Ambush from the burrows.
Blood Channeler (x4)	5-6	Powers the shield, fights back with blood bolts.
Sigil Keeper	7	Seal guardian. Shielded until every channeler is dead.

DESIGN NOTES

- The shield turns a boss into a puzzle: the player must pick a target order and pull channelers apart.
- Rooms run from calm to loud (cells, forge, ritual), so the shrine sits exactly where tension peaks.
- The caged whelps reuse the whelp silhouette in new colors, so the player reads them as allies, not enemies.

The Dragon Crypt

A burial ground for the dragons Morvath drained. Enemies level 6 to 8.



1. Arrival stairs
2. Lower ossuary
3. Supply corridor
4. Upper ossuary
5. Sigil chamber: Sigil Keeper

DESIGN GOAL

Change the threat type. After a wing of ranged cultists, the crypt is about melee pressure and reading the floor: every bone pile could be an enemy.

PLAYER FLOW

1. Arrive at the south end. A respawn point sits right by the stairs.
2. **Lower ossuary.** Four Risen Skeletons lie as harmless bone piles among real dragon skeletons. They pull themselves together when the player comes close or hits one, and a rising skeleton wakes its pack.
3. **Supply corridor.** A health potion rewards clearing the first room. A mana potion waits on the way to the sigil chamber.
4. **Upper ossuary.** Three more skeletons in a tighter room.
5. **Sigil chamber.** The ritual returns in a harder form: four Blood Channelers (Lv 7) shield the Sigil Keeper (Lv 8) around a giant dragon skeleton. Killing him breaks the second seal.

ENCOUNTERS

ENEMY	LV	ROLE
Risen Skeleton (x7)	6-7	Ambush melee. Rises from a bone pile, chases, swings a rusty blade.
Blood Channeler (x4)	7	Powers the Keeper's shield.
Sigil Keeper	8	Seal guardian.

DESIGN NOTES

- Mixing decorative skeletons with Risen Skeletons makes the player read every bone pile, without any trap feeling unfair.
- Pack waking means pulling one skeleton can pull a group, so positioning matters more than in the Ritual Chamber.
- The sigil chamber repeats a known rule (kill the channelers first) at higher stakes, so it tests mastery instead of teaching.

The Crucible

A volcanic forge split by lava rivers. Enemies level 8 to 10.



1. Entry
2. West nest siphon
3. East nest siphon
4. Cage pit siphon
5. Forge island causeways
6. The Forgemaster

DESIGN GOAL

An open, non-linear level: three objectives that can be done in any order, linked in a loop by wooden bridges, with the boss visible in the middle the whole time.

PLAYER FLOW

1. Arrive in the south-west quarter. Only open after two seals are broken.
2. **West nest.** Stolen red eggs sit on lava braziers. Blood Siphons drain them to power the Forgemaster's shield.
3. **East nest.** The second siphon, guarded by a golem, a warden and a hound pack.
4. **Cage pit.** Caged eggs and hounds. The third siphon, with a worm ambush.
5. **Causeways.** When all three siphons break, their eggs turn a safe orange and obsidian causeways rise from the lava moat.
6. **Forgemaster.** No shield now. Blood bolts plus a telegraphed lava breath cone that leaves fire on the floor. His death carries the player back to Morvath's door to watch the last seal break.

ENCOUNTERS

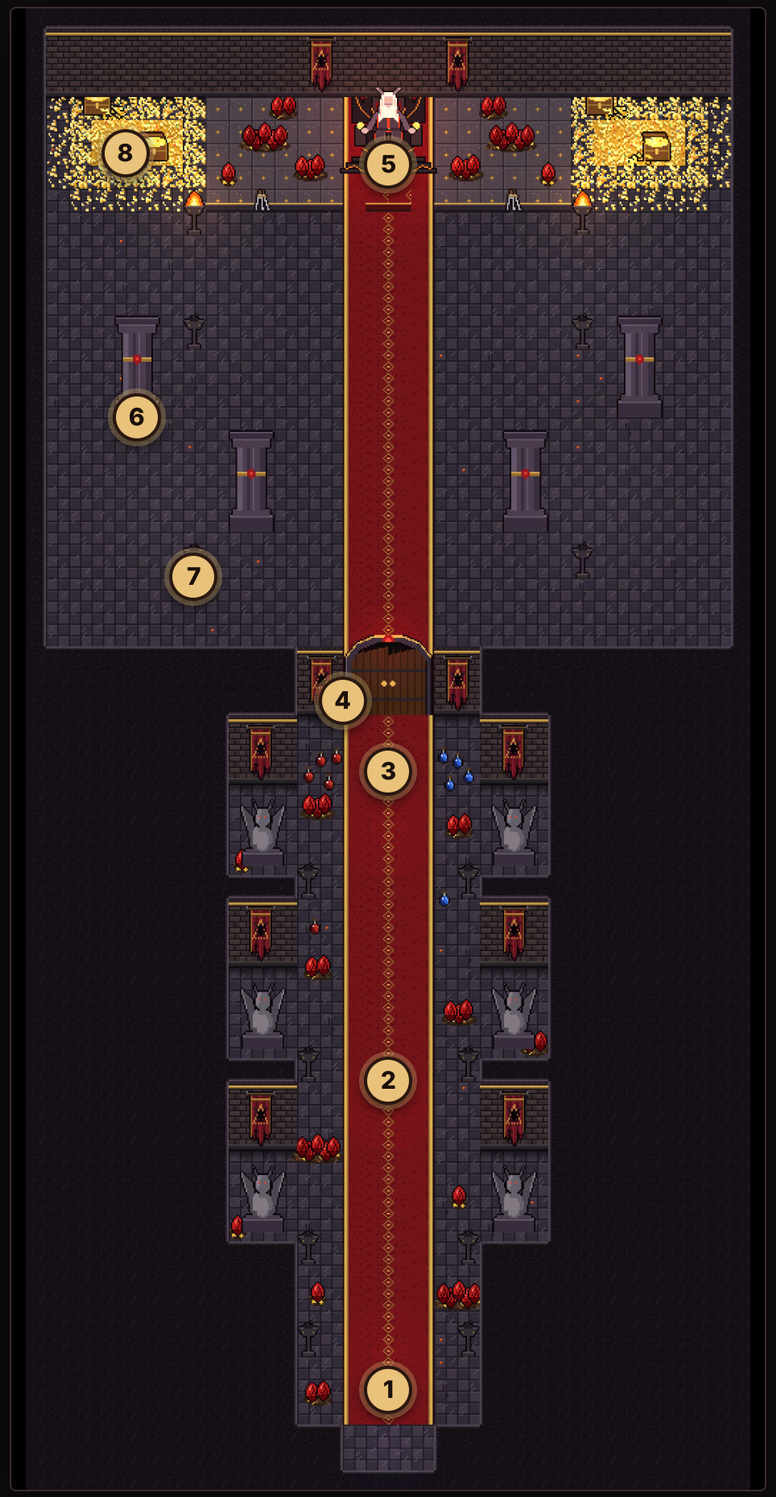
ENEMY	LV	ROLE
Soulfire Hound (x6)	8	Pack hunter. Alerts its pack, crouches, then lunges.
Sigil Warden (x5)	8-9	Ranged pressure behind the melee.
Ember Golem (x3)	9	Tank. Telegraphed slam, burning footprints.
Forgemaster	10	Seal guardian. Shielded while any siphon stands.

ITERATION

- Playtest: after a death, enemies snapped home and re-aggroed instantly. Now they walk home at full health and only re-aggro if the player comes within 4 tiles.

The Throne Room

The long walk up to Morvath, and the great hall where he waits.



DESIGN GOAL

Make the walk in feel tense and uneasy, then hand the player a hall where every prop has a job in the fight: pillars are cover, braziers are objectives, burrows are spawn points.

PLAYER FLOW

1. Arrive at the foot of a long red carpet. A respawn point waits just before the doors.
2. **The walk to the doors.** Morvath speaks three lines as the player walks up. Blue soulfire braziers ignite one by one beside the path, an early hint at how the fight works.
3. Health and mana potions are piled by the doors: a clear signal that the next room is the boss.
4. The Great Doors open on their own, but stay closed until Morvath is done talking.
5. The fight starts when the player reaches the foot of the throne.
6. **Four pillars** (two per side) block his bolt volleys and cast a safe shadow from the Deep Breath.
7. **Four soulfire braziers** are the objective of the final phase.
8. **Four burrows** release whelp waves and, later, whelp reinforcements.

DESIGN NOTES

- The room is symmetrical, so the player can learn one side and trust the other.
- Piles of stolen red eggs line the carpet, so the walk in shows exactly what Morvath has taken.
- The long, narrow hallway slows the pace on purpose: it is the only stretch in the game with nothing to fight, just his voice.
- A respawn point outside the doors keeps retries quick, so a wipe in a long fight costs seconds, not minutes.

ARENA PIECES



Pillar
cover from volleys and breath



Soulfire brazier
Part 4 objective



Brood Whelp
from the burrows



Soulfire orb
Part 2 power-up

Morvath, the Dragon Lord

A four-part boss fight in the Throne Room. The player has to kill him twice.

PART 1: IMMUNE | PART 2: 100% TO 20% | PART 3: HEALS | PART 4: 100% TO 0% (3,500 HP)



PART 1

The Brood

Seated and immune

Five waves of Brood Whelps (12, 16, 20, 24, 38) burst from the four burrows and charge.

- Each wave dies to one or two Fire Circles: the fight opens by rewarding the new ability.
- The bodies stay on the floor. They matter in Part 3.
- Each wave pays XP once, so retries cannot be farmed.



PART 2

The Ashen Prince

100% to 20% health

He steps down and fights. Normal fire does only 10% damage.

- **Soulfire orbs** appear two at a time on six spots. One turns Fireball and Fire Circle blue at full damage for 18s.
- **Bolt volley:** pillars block it.
- **Eruptions:** a glowing circle under the player bursts 1.3s later.



PART 3

The Transformation

Heals 20% back to 100%

He becomes the Obsidian Tyrant and pulls blood beams from every dead whelp, healing to full.

- The player has to kill him twice.
- The four soulfire braziers puff out, setting up the last objective.
- The orbs disappear: the rules change here.



PART 4

The Obsidian Tyrant

Immune while flying

Relight all four soulfire braziers (hold F for 2s each) to knock him out of the air.

- **Knockdown:** stunned 8s, +50% damage taken, unlimited mana.
- **Deep Breath** every 19s from the west, east or north. Only a pillar's shadow is safe.
- Air volleys, swoops toward the middle, and whelp reinforcements every 25s.

DESIGN PILLARS

- **Every part asks a new question:** crowd control, then a resource to manage (orbs), then a route to run (braziers) under pressure.
- **Telegraph everything.** The Deep Breath warning names the direction it comes from, eruptions show a circle first, and the dragon has a warm outline so he never blends into the floor.
- **One job per prop.** Pillars are cover, braziers are the objective, burrows spawn whelps.
- **Fail fast.** A respawn point outside the doors keeps a retry to a few seconds of walking.

ITERATION FROM PLAYTESTS

- The Soulfire timer bar was hidden in Part 4: it suggested one lit brazier was enough to hurt him.
- Players hiding at the bottom pillars rarely saw him during the Deep Breath. Moving his breath closer felt wrong, so he now flies right over the player before breathing from his usual perch.
- He only hovered at the top of the hall. He now swoops toward the middle now and then to fire up close.
- Whelp reinforcements add pressure, but stop once three braziers are lit so the final push stays clean.
- Whelps used to shove the player around. They now pass through and only bite.